

are generally bulkier than those that use other formats. The advantage with Digital8-based camcorders is that they are usually backwards-compatible with the Hi8 (8mm) analogue tapes. So, if you have a large collection of analogue tapes, a Digital8 camcorder can help you convert them to digital, transfer them to a PC, etc.

MiniDV is by and large the most popular digital video recording format. It is about half the size of an audio cassette, and can record about 45 to 90 minutes of footage. As with Digital8, recording quality is excellent and, depending on the camcorder, it can record at 500-line resolutions or more. It is a proven tape format and is widely available. One advantage with MiniDV (when used over FireWire) is that it is automatically recognised by movie editing programs. It can automatically wind back the tape and begin the transfer from tape to hard drive with a single click. Additionally, MiniDV tapes support the newer High Definition video standard, which is slowly replacing the current Standard Definition video standard.

MicroMV is the smallest cassette format available, and records directly to tape in the MPEG-2 encoding format. However, MicroMV is not as popular as MiniDV, and Sony, its manufacturers, are also losing interest in supporting the format. Given this situation, it is best to ignore MicroMV-based camcorders, whatever may be the attractions (bargain basement prices, feature lists, etc).

There are other tape formats such as DVCam and ProDV. These are more robust and support better compression, but they are primarily for professionals: camcorders that support these formats start at Rs 5 lakh and higher!

2.1.2. Disc

Camcorders that support both optical discs (DVDs) as well as magnetic discs (hard disks) are becoming increasingly available.

DVD-based camcorders can, depending on the recording quality settings, record 20 minutes to 1 hour of MPEG-2 video. The video